Beyond religiosity

Better crowd regulation could have prevented the Kolkata pandal tragedy

This year's Durga Puja in Kolkata was meant to be truly special. The first after the Bharatiya Janata Party formed the government in West Bengal, Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari wanted the pandals to showcase his party's commitment to Hindu religiosity as well as to demonstrate the efficiency of the administrative machinery under him. He made it a point to highlight that the number of pandals in the State had increased by 25% over last year to more than 57,000. He was a visible presence at pandals across the city. Union Home Minister Amit Shah was in Kolkata as well to add heft and leverage to the puja's popular appeal. But disaster struck at Kolkata's Girish Park area on Saturday, as 19 people lost their lives in a stampede that could have been avoided with better organisation and crowd regulation. Both the police and the puja organisers failed to anticipate the sudden surge of the crowd at the venue.

Puja pandals, just like Mumbai's Ganapati installations, are often sites of creativity and festivity; they have generally been accident-free despite the participation of a large number of people. The *Chorbagan Sarbojanin Durgotstab*'s theme this year was Beyond Sound. With a narrow entry and exit, the creators apparently sought to give an experience to visitors that involved controlling the light falling inside. The surrounding lanes were narrow city gullies that cannot hold two cars at the same time. Unanticipated too – at a time of retreat of the monsoon – was the rain that struck India's east coast with heavy thunder and lightning in the evening. As people barged into the pandal seeking safety – visitors keep moving inside the Durga Puja pandals typically – the organisers requested people to leave fearing that the structure might collapse. Packed crowds can be incident-free only if sudden surges of movement, often triggered by panic, are avoided throughout. In Kolkata, panic apparently stemmed from the announcement regarding the safety of the structure, though the fear about the structure's safety was justified. The effort should have been to wean the crowd away in a regulated manner. The government has promised an inquiry and deterrent follow-up action. There is the question of whether in the government's drive to make the celebrations spectacular and grand, safe management practices got ignored at the event. Although Mr. Adhikari said the police helped rush the victims to hospitals, he also indicated that only temporary home guards had been posted at the pandal. Effective deployment of experienced police personnel may have helped avoid the tragedy.

Treacherous waters

Access to safe transport is of utmost importance in remote villages

River crossings on stretches of the Ganga in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar are notoriously unsafe as poorly lit, unregistered boats ply with bare access to lifesaving equipment. Overcrowded vessels, operated by untrained or underaged people, add to the risks, and enforcement action only follows an accident. These boats are not the preserve of the poor but are also used by government personnel, teachers, and bank employees: many areas lack reliable alternatives, making the riverine journeys the sole option. On October 13, at least 13 children drowned when a country-made boat capsized in Raghopur, in Bihar's Vaishali district, after setting off at 8.30 p.m. for a memorial feast in an adjoining village, even though rides are prohibited post sunset. The boat was visibly dilapidated, including a hole in the deck through which it drew water, and was being operated by a young boatman. There were at least half a dozen other people on the vessel when it capsized despite its reported capacity having been five. The riverine tract in Raghopur is continuously shaped by sediment deposits and has historically been hard to access, especially during the monsoons. Raghopur lacks all-weather roads, and has a history of being isolated during floods. The first section of the Kachchi Dargah-Bidupur bridge, between Patna and Raghopur, was ready in June 2025, but the monsoons still flooded the approach road and blocked access. The overarching motif across these episodes has been a consistent lack of safer alternatives, including the general paucity of public transport. A choate regulatory framework, including the Model Rules 2011 under the Bengal Ferries Act 1885 and the Inland Vessels Act 2021, has also not prevented training programmes and inspections from lagging behind the proliferation of unsafe transport practices.

That all those who drowned on October 13 were children deepens the sense of tragedy. In general, children warrant additional, more sensitive socio-economic support. The Bombay High Court had recently upbraided the Maharashtra government for failing to arrange transportation for over 200 children from villages near Chandoli National Park and Sahyadri Tiger Reserve; they had to walk several kilometres to reach school, braving the risk of wildlife encounters. Such precarity persists in Hingoli, Palghar, and Nashik in Maharashtra alone; similar situations have also been created by school reorganisation programmes that do not sufficiently account for children's safety when shuttering infeasible facilities. The children who drowned in Vaishali were not headed to school, but the risk exposure is paramount. The ultimate tragedy is that access to ordinary childhood activities remains contingent, in so many economically disadvantaged communities, on accepting dangers that public institutions already know how to prevent.

Developing minds in a digital world, a changing India



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Each evening, a familiar scene unfolds in homes around the world. A teenager moves seamlessly between chats, videos, social media, and games on their phone. Homework is completed using the latest Artificial Intelligence (AI) platform. Screens increasingly dominate everyday life. This is a profound change in how developing minds experience the world, learn, and grow.

These changes are particularly significant for India, with approximately 65 crore people under the age of 25 and one of the world's largest and fastest-growing technological ecosystems. Digital engagement by this vast young population continues to grow as education, recreation, and social interaction increasingly move online.

The digital world has brought undeniable benefits, from unprecedented access to information and educational resources to new ways of communicating, creating, and learning. Recent advances in AI have expanded these possibilities even further. Nonetheless, these digital environments have also introduced a powerful and largely unregulated force into children's lives – one we are only beginning to understand.

A brain under construction

Technology itself is not the problem. The concern is constant exposure to powerful digital tools during critical periods of development, when the brain systems underlying cognition, emotion, and behaviour are still maturing. These concerns extend beyond childhood. The prefrontal cortex – which supports attention, working memory, planning, decision-making, and impulse control – continues to mature into early adulthood.

Digital environments provide a dense, repetitive stream of experiences that can shape how brain circuits develop – strengthening some pathways while leaving others underdeveloped. Given the brain's plasticity during early life, such patterns may have lasting effects, shaping how young people think, feel, and act across the lifespan.

Emerging research links high levels of screen time to alterations in brain structure and connectivity. Though revealing, such findings do not establish causation. They do, however, underscore the need to better understand how digital experiences affect cognitive development, including attention, memory, self-control, and creativity.

Social media platforms are particularly appealing during adolescence, when belonging, peer evaluation, and social approval are especially salient. These platforms are designed to capture and sustain attention by exploiting basic features of cognition, emotion, and reward. Short videos, autoplay, infinite scroll, algorithmic recommendations, and social feedback create reinforcement loops that deliver novelty and rewards – likes, shares, and comments – in a rapid but unpredictable manner.

> Digital innovation must be balanced with children's cognitive, emotional and social development

This form of variable reinforcement encourages repetitive checking and rapid attention shifts, potentially making it harder to sustain attention on a single task. Over time, such patterns of engagement may shape what young people come to expect from everyday experiences. When digital rewards are immediate and constantly accessible, ordinary experiences – having a face-to-face conversation, practising a skill, or simply sitting with one's thoughts – may feel less rewarding by comparison.

Offloading mental effort

Generative AI has rapidly transformed how we engage with the world. Unlike earlier technologies, AI does not just assist with mental effort; it can supplant it. Humans have long used tools to reduce cognitive load. Taking a photograph in a crowded parking lot, for example, means we do not have to remember where we parked. Such cognitive offloading is not inherently problematic.

The concern arises when AI replaces the mental effort necessary for learning. Students can now use AI platforms to generate ideas, organise arguments, write essays, and summarise material. Used thoughtfully, these tools can enhance the learning process. When used as a substitute for independent thinking, however, AI can undermine the cognitive effort through which knowledge and skills develop.

Grappling with difficult questions, finding the right words, making mistakes, and revising arguments are central to learning. If AI routinely eliminates these experiences, we should rightly ask what the impact will be on young people's ability to think critically, use informed judgement, and persevere when answers are not immediately available.

A related concern is what happens when technology replaces not just our intellectual efforts but our idle moments. Though rarely welcomed, boredom creates space for imagination, reflection, creativity, and the development of a rich inner life. When every free moment is filled with stimulation, young people have fewer opportunities to think, wonder, daydream, or reflect.

Neuroplasticity – the brain's lifelong capacity to adapt to experience, learning, and the environment – offers another perspective on how digital technology shapes young minds. Today's youth are certainly adapting to a world very different from that of previous generations. Indeed, many young people exhibit impressive abilities to filter information, navigate complex digital environments, and switch among information sources.

We must be cautious, however, when evaluating whether these changes are beneficial or harmful. It is important to consider what may be gained – and lost – as young minds adapt to today's technologically advanced ecosystem.

In effect, young people worldwide are participating in a vast, largely uncontrolled experiment in how sustained exposure to digital technology may shape developing brains and minds. Meanwhile, the corporations designing these digital tools and devices have strong financial incentives to keep young people – their current and future users – engaged.

Safeguarding the future

India's youth are growing up in an environment that was unimaginable until quite recently. Whatever our concerns, we cannot simply ignore or reject digital technology. Children will use it. Our responsibility is to help them use it capably, thoughtfully, and responsibly.

Parents need practical, evidence-based guidance. Children should have device-free times and places, protected study periods, healthy sleep routines, and opportunities for unstructured time. The objective is not to eliminate screens, but to ensure that they do not occupy every available moment.

Schools and educators must preserve what might be called productive struggle – the effort involved in thinking, writing, reasoning, solving problems, and working through uncertainty. Digital tools, including AI, can support analysis, revision, and feedback without replacing critical thinking. Greater emphasis should be placed on independent cognitive engagement, including oral examinations, supervised writing, and applied problem-solving.

Digital platforms – especially those targeted at young people – must face greater scrutiny and accountability. Policymakers should require companies to provide stronger evidence about how their products affect the cognitive and emotional development of children and adolescents. Governments must also support independent research capable of informing policies and regulations as these technologies continue to evolve.

We should not wait for definitive evidence of harm before asking whether the digital environments we are creating are conducive to healthy development. A young mind needs stimulation, but also silence; information, but also reflection; assistance, but also struggle. We can embrace technological progress while still protecting the experiences through which children and adolescents learn to think, imagine, reflect, and grow.

A case for joining the global carbon coalition



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On July 31, nearly 500 Indian companies across seven industrial sectors filed their first-ever compliance reports under the national Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS). The country's scheme – on paper since 2023 – is now live with binding targets, penalties and real entities. The first credits are due to be issued in October, with trading on power exchanges expected to follow between November and January. In May, the European Union, China, and Brazil launched the Open Coalition on Compliance Carbon Markets (OCCCM) in Florence, aimed at aligning the way the world's compliance carbon markets communicate with each other. Germany and New Zealand joined as the first new members; Canada, France, Norway, Singapore, Türkiye and the United Kingdom have since followed. On September 14, at its meeting in Wuhan, the coalition adopted its first work plan.

India has stayed outside so far. With its own market now live, the more interesting question is no longer whether India can afford to build a carbon price – it already has. It is whether India can afford to sit outside the room where its rules get written. Or is it best avoided due to unforeseen risks? The OCCCM is a collaborative initiative for exchange on carbon pricing mechanisms; monitoring, reporting and verification (MRV) systems, carbon accounting methodologies, and rules related to the potential use of high-integrity offsets.

In India, the government has adopted a compliance carbon market framework in the form of a Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS), which is currently in its first phase. The CCTS (compliance) is set up to deliver on India's Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC) targets and the 2070 net-zero goal.

The issue of a carbon price

There are two key reasons why India must seriously consider joining the OCCCM. The first is the proliferation of carbon pricing systems worldwide. The idea of having a carbon price as a key instrument, supported by complementary policy instruments, is back at the high table. It minimises the economy-wide cost of mitigation (critical for the global South) and can promote innovation while minimising the impact on the vulnerable. It can also deliver significant fiscal revenues at a time when government resources are increasingly stretched, including by the impacts of climate change – from heatwaves to devastating floods. As of now, over 50 countries have instituted carbon pricing measures. As the world advances towards a net-zero future, the likelihood that more and more countries adopt a carbon price is high.

> India should join the Open Coalition on Compliance Carbon Markets, as it aligns well with the country's decarbonisation choices

We could be looking at a future where a bulk of emissions would be priced. At some point, more and more of these domestic carbon pricing systems will be linked – even if partially – to better coordinate. While the beginning of OCCCM focuses on knowledge exchange, one potential long-term strategic outcome is improved interoperability among domestic carbon pricing systems. It could be valuable to link India's CCTS (compliance) to other carbon trading systems, given the potential to earn revenue from jurisdictions with more stringent mitigation targets.

On 'climate clubs'

The second is to be better prepared in case a coalition along the lines of the EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) develops. The idea of 'climate clubs' is re-emerging as geopolitics fractures United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) discussions and attention turns to implementation. A report on a climate coalition centred around the CBAM issue was released in the context of an independent council convened by the COP30 President, Ambassador André Aranha Corrêa do Lago (The writers of this article are the co-authors of the report). The report describes alternative scenarios for CBAM coalitions in which there could be uniform or differentiated carbon prices across member-countries, incentives for member-countries, and penalties for non-member countries. With the European Union CBAM now operational, and many other countries contemplating their own versions of CBAM, being better prepared on this front is absolutely critical for India. While the OCCCM does not mention CBAM explicitly – most probably because of the sharp reactions the term evokes, especially during climate negotiations – OCCCM's objectives around the MRV, carbon accounting, and domestic compliance markets are very relevant for being better prepared to deal with the CBAM world.

Why joining matters now

Are there potential risks in joining the coalition? The coalition is about better alignment of domestic compliance markets and carbon pricing across countries. It does not seek to enforce any mitigation targets or any other decision. However, as discussions evolve, some critical decisions are likely to be made by coalition members. OCCCM's governance structure consists of high-level meetings (the highest decision-making body), executive-level meetings, thematic working groups and a Secretariat. It is critical to be in the room and shape the discussions rather than respond to the developments as an outsider. The risk is more in being an outsider. That Brazil is a founding member, and other like-minded developing countries are in the process of becoming members, should be a source of comfort for India.

Some aspects of the future world are likely: geopolitics will remain fractured, climate negotiations will continue to meet logjams, the profile of carbon pricing will continue to rise across countries, and efforts from outside the Paris Agreement framework will become increasingly important to achieving the agreement's goals. In this context, the role played by country-backed climate coalitions will likely grow.

The OCCCM aligns well with India's decarbonisation choices and offers a useful platform not just to learn about carbon markets, but also to be better prepared to engage with other national carbon pricing architectures and border carbon taxes within the evolving geopolitical landscape. India should consider making this move sooner rather than later.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Calm communication

One careless announcement can turn a hall full of devotees into a scene of panic, because a crowd often follows the loudest voice, not the wisest one (Front page, October 18). Every pandal or place of gatherings should therefore have one trained 'Voice of Calm' — a designated announcer equipped with a script of simple, pre-approved messages for emergencies involving rain, overcrowding or fire. No one else should be allowed to use the microphone during an emergency. Pandals should have clearly marked entry and exit routes, kept free of stalls and parked vehicles, along with a fixed crowd limit, a rain contingency plan and adequate lighting. The police, fire services and organisers should conduct a drill. A festival should be remembered for its devotion, not its dangers.

K. Chidanand Kumar,
Bengaluru

Deva

When two stalwart music directors dominated Kollywood, Tamil film composer Deva made his mark with gaana songs. Besides hits such as "Autokaaran" from *Baashha* and "Vanthenda Paalkaran" from *Annamalai*, his melodic compositions included "Sivappu Lolakku" from *Kaadhal Kottai*, "Manam Virumbuthey" from *Nerukku Ner* and "Nilavai Kondu Vaa" from *Vaali*. His music showcased his versatility. Today's music directors should revive the emphasis on melody.

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Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.